Topic 5 — Sixth Century BCE

Covers syllabus (click to expand)

Political Condition of Sixth Century BCE | Sixteen Mahajanapadas | Mahajanapadas of Uttar Pradesh | Capitals of Mahajanapadas | Expansion of Mahajanapadas | Rise of Magadha | Haryanka Dynasty | Shishunaga Dynasty | Nanda Dynasty | Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)

Sources baked in: NCERT *Themes in Indian History* I, RS Sharma, Anguttara Nikaya, Bhagavati Sutra, Ghatnachakra Political Condition (Sixth Century BCE), UPPCS + UKPCS Prelims PYQs **Weight:** ★★★ — 16 capitals, UP list, Magadha dynasty order, Pataliputra founder vs capital shift **Last verified:** September 2026 **Current Affairs:** N/A — static

5.1 Political Condition of Sixth Century BCE

Iron Age Gangetic states | second urbanisation | age of the Buddha and Mahavira

- The Later Vedic **jana** becomes a territorial **janapada**. Sixteen of those states are called **mahajanapadas**.
- Politics is war and marriage. There is no pan-Indian empire until Nanda–Maurya.
- **Iron** ploughs and weapons open forest in the middle Ganga. The **chaturanga** army has infantry, cavalry, chariots, and elephants.
- **NBPW** (about 700–200 BCE) is the deluxe table-ware of this urban phase. It **starts in mahajanapada towns** and continues into the Mauryas. **PGW** is the Later Vedic doab ware.
- This is the **second urbanisation** after Harappa. Towns show mud or burnt-brick ramparts, craft quarters, and **setthi** merchants.
- **Punch-marked** silver (*karshapana*, bent bars), also called **Aahat** coins, appears. There is no gold dinara yet. These are the earliest extant Indian coins and run from about the seventh–sixth centuries BCE into the Mauryan age.
- Two constitutions exist: **monarchy** and **gana-sangha**. A gana-sangha is an assembly of kshatriya clans, not adult-male democracy.
- The Shakyas of Kapilavastu sit under Kosala. They are **not** one of the 16 names.
- Revenue language separates four dues. **Bhaga** (भाग) is a produce share (often one-sixth). **Bali** (बलि) is tribute. **Shulka** is a toll. **Visti** is labour.
- Officers in this horizon include *mahamatta*, *senanayaka*, and *bhandagarika*.
- The standard list of 16 is the Buddhist **Anguttara Nikaya**. The Jain list is the **Bhagavati / Vyakhya Prajnapti** (names differ: Anga, Banga, Malay, and others). Puranas give the Magadha dynasties. Greek writers appear only at the **Nanda** end.
- **Panini** of **Pushkalavati** (Gandhara) in the *Ashtadhyayi* names about **22** janapadas. The three he stresses as important are **Magadha, Asmaka, and Kamboja**.

- The *Mahaparinirvana-sutra* names six Buddha-age metros: **Champa, Rajagriha, Varanasi (Benaras), Saketa, Kaushambi, and Shravasti**.
- In the northwest, Gandhara and Kamboja already sit on the **Achaemenid** fringe. **Alexander in 326 BCE** closes this age. It is not a 600 BCE event.
- Buddha and Mahavira teach in this century. This file is **states, capitals, and Magadha houses**, not the Four Noble Truths. The same century is a wider intellectual upheaval (new faiths in the middle Ganga; parallel questioning elsewhere). Full religious teaching sits in the Religious Movements chapter.

> **Logic:** The 6th century BCE is not Mauryan India. NBPW is not PGW.

5.1a Second Urbanisation — Causes and Features

~600–300 BCE | iron + towns + coins | after Harappan decline

- **Iron tools** opened forest land and strengthened plough agriculture in the middle Ganga.
- Surplus grain supported **specialised crafts** and a merchant class (*setthi*).
- **Fortified towns** with ramparts, craft quarters, and administrative centres multiplied.
- **Punch-marked silver** (*karshapana*) eased wider exchange; writing spread on pots and seals.
- **NBPW** marks elite urban table culture; it begins in mahajanapada towns and continues into Mauryan strata.
- This phase is the **second urbanisation** because the first was the Harappan system.

5.2 Sixteen Mahajanapadas

Solasa mahajanapada | Anguttara Nikaya | Jain *Bhagavati* also knows 16

#	Mahajanapada	Capital	River / belt
1	**Kashi**	Varanasi	Ganga
2	**Kosala**	Shravasti / Ayodhya	Sarayu
3	**Anga**	Champa	Ganga (port)
4	**Magadha** (मगध)	Rajagriha → Pataliputra	Ganga + Son
5	**Vajji** (Vrijji)	Vaishali	Gandak belt
6	**Malla**	Kushinagar / Pava	Rapti–Gandak edge
7	**Chedi**	Shuktimati	Ken / Bundelkhand
8	**Vatsa**	Kaushambi	Yamuna
9	**Kuru**	Indraprastha / Hastinapur	Yamuna–Ganga doab
10	**Panchala**	Ahichchhatra / Kampilya	Ganga (Rohilkhand)

#	Mahajanapada	Capital	River / belt
11	**Matsya**	Viratnagar (Bairat)	Rajasthan
12	**Surasena**	Mathura	Yamuna
13	**Asmaka** (Assaka)	**Potana** / Potali	**Godavari** (गोदावरी)
14	**Avanti**	Ujjain / Mahishmati	Shipra / **Narmada** (नर्मदा)
15	**Gandhara** (गांधार)	Taxila (also Pushkalavati)	Indus
16	**Kamboja**	Rajapura	Hindu Kush

Kashi - Kashi is the strongest state *early*, then becomes a Kosala pawn. Bimbisara later receives it as **dowry**. - Its capital is **Varanasi**. It rivals Kosala, Anga, and Magadha for supremacy in the early sixth century BCE.

Kosala - The king is **Prasenajit** (Pasenadi). His son **Vidudabha** wrecks the Shakyas. - Capitals are **Shravasti** and **Saket / Ayodhya**. Jetavana at Shravasti is the gift of **Anathapindika**. It is not a Magadha gift. - Excavation memory places ancient Shravasti at **Saheth–Maheth**. The town plan is remembered as **crescentic**.

Anga - **Champa** is a Ganga **emporium** in the Bhagalpur–Munger belt. Epic and Puranic memory also call it **Malini**. - Champa ranks among the six Buddha-age metros. Anga is the **first** Magadha annexation, under Bimbisara.

Magadha - **Girivraja / Rajagriha** sits in a ring of five hills. Iron and elephants are the resource facts. - Epic memory of **Jarasandha / Brihadratha** is Puranic pre-Haryanka. It is not the dynasty list for papers. - Buddhist texts treat **Bimbisara** as the first great historical Magadha ruler and the real founder of the Magadha empire line that papers care about.

Vajji - Vajji is a **gana** of **eight** clans led by the **Licchavis**. Videha / Mithila and the **Jnatrika** clan of Mahavira sit inside the league. - Papers often say the **Licchavis of Vaishali** founded the world's first republic. Vaishali was the largest and most powerful republic of the Buddha age. - The Suttanipata calls Vaishali **Magadhham Puram**. King **Chetak** heads the Licchavis; his daughter **Chelana** marries Bimbisara. - The Buddha praises their frequent assemblies.

Malla - One Malla town is **Kushinagar**, the site of the Buddha's death. The other is **Pava**. - Malla **Pava** is **not** Jain **Pavapuri**, where Mahavira died in Magadha.

Chedi - The capital is **Sotthivati / Suktimati (Shuktimati)** in Bundelkhand and its fringe. - Epic memory names Sisupala. Later **Kharavela** (खारवेल) of Kalinga belongs to a Chedi line; his **Hathigumpha** inscription is the Nanda–Kalinga evidence paper, not a sixth-century Chedi capital fact.

Vatsa - The king is **Udayana**. Kaushambi is a Yamuna fort-city. G.R. Sharma excavated it. - Do not confuse this **Udayana of Vatsa** with **Udayin of Magadha**.

Kuru - Vedic glory has already faded. Sites are Hastinapur and Indraprastha in the Meerut–Delhi–Thanesar belt. PGW overlay comes first, then NBPW.

Panchala - North Panchala has **Ahichchhatra** in Bareilly. South Panchala has **Kampilya** in Farrukhabad. Epic memory makes it Draupadi's home. - Famous **Kanyakubja (Kannauj)** lies in the Panchala belt.

Boundaries run from Himalayan foothills to the Chambal, with Kosala east and Kuru west. - Panchala begins as a monarchy. By Kautilya's horizon it appears as a republic.

Matsya - The capital is Viratnagar / Bairat in the Jaipur–Alwar–Bharatpur belt. Matsya is **not** Mathura — Mathura belongs to **Surasena**.

Surasena - The capital is **Mathura**, in the Braja / Vrishni–Andhaka / Krishna belt. Mathura is the **2020** capital fact. - Greek writers call the people **Sourasenoi** and the city **Mathora**.

Asmaka - Asmaka is the **only** mahajanapada **south of the Vindhyas**, between the Godavari and Narmada belts. The 2020 capital is **Potana / Potali**, not Satavahana Paithan (though some lists also remember Pratisthana).

Avanti - North Avanti is **Ujjain (Avantika)**. South Avanti is **Mahishmati** on the Narmada. The king is **Chanda Pradyota**. - **Jivaka** was sent from Magadha to treat him. Avanti falls to **Shishunaga**. - The legend of **Udayana and Vasavadatta** is set when Vatsa's Udayana is held at **Ujjain**. Bhasa's drama **Svapnavasavadattam** tells that story.

Gandhara - **Taxila** (तक्षशिला) is the university-town and an Achaemenid satrapy. **Pushkalavati** is the second pole. - Ramayana memory says **Taksha**, son of Bharata, founded Takshashila. **Panini** is born in the Pushkalavati / Gandhara world.

Kamboja - Kamboja is known for **horses** and Ashvaka tribes. Capitals in match lists are **Rajapura / Hataka**. It is the farthest northwest of the 16.

- The four-power fight is among **Magadha, Kosala, Vatsa, and Avanti**. **Shakya is not one of the 16.**

> **Logic:** There are 16, not 18. The 2020 paper swaps Matsya with Surasena. A Jain list exists, but papers use the Buddhist 16.

5.2a Gana-Sangha Polity — Vajji and Malla

Oligarchic kshatriya clans | assembly rule | Magadha's hardest target

- A **gana-sangha** is rule by an assembly of kshatriya clans, not a hereditary single king.
- The Buddha praised the **Vajji** league for frequent, well-attended assemblies.
- **Vajji** united **eight clans**. Leading houses were the **Licchavis** of Vaishali, the **Videhas** of Mithila, and the **Jnatrikas** (Mahavira's clan).
- **Malla** was a gana with two centres: **Kushinagar** and **Pava**.
- Assembly sites used open pavilions such as the **santhagara**; decisions needed clan consensus.
- Gana-sanghas fell because they could not match Magadhan standing armies, siege engines, and ministerial intrigue.
- **Magadha** remained a **monarchy** through the Haryanka age. It was never itself a gana-sangha.
- Buddha-age "earlier republic" lists used in papers commonly include Shakya (Kapilavastu), Bhagga, Buli, Kalam, Koliya, Malla (Kushinara / Pava), Moriya, Licchavi, and Videha. **Yaudheya** is **not** in that earlier list — it is a later plains gana.

Feature	Gana-sangha (e.g. Vajji, Malla)	Monarchy (e.g. Magadha, Kosala)
Ruler	Clan assembly / oligarchy	Hereditary king
Capital examples	Vaishali, Kushinagar	Rajagriha, Shravasti
Army	Clan levies	Standing **chaturanga** force
trap	Vajji is **not** one of the "four monarchies"	Magadha is **not** a gana

5.3 Mahajanapadas of Uttar Pradesh

Eight touch present UP | Magadha is the classic trap

- Eight of the sixteen touch present-day Uttar Pradesh: **Kashi, Kosala, Vatsa, Kuru, Panchala, Malla, Surasena**, and **Chedi** on the Bundelkhand edge.
- **Magadha, Anga, and Vajji** are in **Bihar**, not Uttar Pradesh.
- **Avanti** is in **Madhya Pradesh**. **Matsya** is in **Rajasthan** (थार). **Asmaka** is in the Deccan. **Gandhara** and **Kamboja** are in the northwest.

State	UP fact
Kashi	Varanasi — oldest continuous city on this list
Kosala	**Ayodhya** (अयोध्या) + **Shravasti** (Saheth-Maheth, crescent plan); Prasenajit
Vatsa	**Kaushambi** (Prayagraj) — Udayana; NBPW + rampart
Kuru	**Hastinapur** (हस्तिनापुर) (Meerut); Indraprastha = Delhi NCR
Panchala	**Ahichchhatra** (Bareilly), Kampilya (Farrukhabad); Kanyakubja belt
Malla	**Kushinagar** + Pava
Surasena	**Mathura**
Chedi	Banda–Chitrakoot / Bundelkhand — capital Shuktimati / Sotthivati

- **Kalpi** in Jalaun district sits on the **Yamuna**. Ancient memory calls it **Kalpriya**; tradition links its building to King **Vasudeva** (about fourth century BCE / early historic horizon in coaching dumps).

> **Logic:** “Magadha, Vaishali, or Champa in Uttar Pradesh” is false.

5.4 Capitals of Mahajanapadas

Dual capitals plus the 2020 four | full 16 pairs are in 5.2

- Several of the 16 have **two poles**. **Kosala** has Shravasti and Ayodhya. **Kuru** has Hastinapur and Indraprastha.

- **Avanti** has Ujjain in the north and Mahishmati in the south. **Panchala** has Ahichchhatra in the north and Kampilya in the south.
- **Magadha** has **Rajgir** (राजगीर), then **Pataliputra** after Udayin's shift.
- The 2020 paper spellings are **Sursena, Asmak, Potan, Virat Nagar**. Mathura is Surasena, never Matsya.

> [!TIP] **Exam Anchor [UPPCS Prelims 2020, Q6]:** Match Mahajanapada capitals: Matsya = Viratnagar; Kuru = Indraprastha; Shurasena = Mathura; Ashmaka = Potana/Potali. *(See Q1 in Complete PYQ Bank below)*
>
> **Logic:** Mathura is **Surasena**, never Matsya.

5.5 Expansion of Mahajanapadas

Who ate whom — Magadha wins the century

Sixteenth-century BCE politics is a chain of stronger states swallowing weaker ones. **Magadha** finishes on top.

Early ranking

- Early ranking puts **Kashi** first among equals.
- Then **Kosala** eclipses Kashi.
- Then **Magadha** eclipses everyone.

Magadha's bites

- **Bimbisara** first swallows **Anga** and its Champa port.
- His marriages buy peace with Kosala (the **Kashi dowry**), with the Licchavis, and with Madra.
- **Ajatashatru** kills Bimbisara, then fights Kosala over Kashi.
- Settlement comes when he marries **Vajira**, Prasenajit's daughter.
- He then fights a **~16-year** war on **Vajji**. The full Cause → Course → Result card for that war sits in the Magadhan expansion section below.
- War-engines are the **rathamusala** (scythed chariot) and the **mahashilakantaka** (stone-thrower).
- Minister **Vassakara**, with **Sunidha**, sows discord in the Licchavi assembly.
- They fortify **Pataligrama**, the seed of Pataliputra.

What Magadha does not finish first

- **Vidudabha** of Kosala destroys Kapilavastu and the Shakyas. That is Kosala internal, not Magadha.
- **Avanti** under Pradyota stays independent until **Shishunaga**.
- Vatsa is usually tied by marriage, not by a first conquest.
- Gana-sanghas fall last.
- Gandhara and Kamboja meet **Persia then the Greeks**, not Magadha first.
- The **Nandas** roll leftover Kuru, Panchala, and Kalinga into one Gangetic empire. Then the Mauryas.

> **Logic:** The first Magadha bite is **Anga**. The longest fight is **Vajji**. Avanti is not Bimbisara's prize.

5.5a Wars of Magadhan Expansion — Cause, Course, Result

Bimbisara's annexation of Anga

Cause: Anga's **Champa** port controlled lower-Ganga trade; an eastern base was useful against Kashi rivalry.

Course: Bimbisara campaigned against Anga and took **Champa**. Marriage ties with Kosala had eased the western flank.

Result: Anga became the **first** Magadha annexation. Magadha gained a river emporium toward Bengal.

Ajatashatru's war with Kosala (Kashi)

Cause: After parricide, Kosala under **Prasenajit** backed anti-Magadhan factions; **Kashi** was the prize city.

Course: Ajatashatru fought Kosala, then sealed peace by marrying **Vajira**, Prasenajit's daughter.

Result: Magadha kept leverage over **Kashi**. Kosala remained a rival until later Nanda pressure.

Ajatashatru's war with the Vajji confederacy (~16 years)

Cause: Vajji wealth, Vaishali's assemblies, and fear of a Licchavi–Kosala league threatened Magadhan supremacy.

Course: Ajatashatru used the **rathamusala** (scythed chariot) and **mahashilakantaka** (catapult). Minister **Vassakara** sowed discord inside the Licchavi assembly. **Pataligrama** was fortified as a forward base.

Result: Vajji was absorbed into Magadha. **Pataligrama** became the seed of **Pataliputra**.

Vidudabha's destruction of the Shakyas

Cause: Kosala's **Vidudabha** resented Shakyas of Kapilavastu after a court insult tradition.

Course: He invaded Shakya territory under Kosalan suzerainty.

Result: The **Shakyas** disappear as a political unit. This is **Kosala internal**, not a Magadhan conquest.

Shishunaga's conquest of Avanti

Cause: Avanti under the **Pradyota** line had long balanced Magadha, Vatsa, and Kosala.

Course: Shishunaga marched against Avanti and ended the Pradyota house.

Result: **Ujjain** entered Magadha's orbit. Avanti ceased to be one of the four great monarchies.

Mahapadma Nanda's conquests

Cause: Leftover mahajanapada boards (Kuru, Panchala, Kosala, Vatsa) still blocked a Gangetic empire.

Course: **Mahapadma Nanda** overthrew the Shishunaga tail and rolled up the middle Ganga belt.

Result: First large **Gangetic empire** before the Mauryas. Titles **ekarat** (एकराट्), **sarvakshatrantaka** (सर्वक्षत्रान्तक), and **aparoparashurama** (अपरोपरशुराम) belong here.

5.6 Rise of Magadha

Why this Bihar state, not Kosala or Avanti

- Magadha has alluvium and rain. **Iron** comes from the Rajgir–Chhotanagpur fringe. **Elephants** and timber come from the eastern forests.
- **Rajagriha / Girivraja** is a five-hill fort. Named hills include Vaibhara and Vipula.
- **Pataliputra** sits at the Ganga and the **Son**. Ancient geography places the **Ganga to the north** and the **Son to the west**. The site gives a river navy, tolls, and a hinge between the upper Ganga and the delta.
- **Ajatashatru** fortifies **Pataligrama** during the Vajji war. **Udayin** first chooses Pataliputra as the Magadhan **capital**. Later houses (Shishunaga, Nanda, Maurya) keep it.
- Roads run east to Anga and Bengal, and west up-river to Kashi, Kosala, and Vatsa. Magadha did **not** rise on Arabian-Sea trade.
- Unbroken hungry houses follow: Haryanka, then Shishunaga, then Nanda. Rivals had one strong king each — Prasenajit, Pradyota, Udayana — then gaps.
- Bimbisara's Kosala princess brought the **Kashi dowry**. His Licchavi wife is **Chellana** (daughter of Chetak). His Madra wife is **Khema**.
- A standing army and *mahamattas* make a proto-Mauryan machine. The finished *Arthashastra* (अर्थशास्त्र) org-chart is Mauryan, not Haryanka.

Dynasty	Approx. span (Buddhist coaching line)
Haryanka	~544–412 BCE
Shishunaga	~412–344 BCE
Nanda	~344–321 BCE
Maurya	~321–184 BCE
Shunga	~184–75 BCE

> **Logic:** Magadha did not "rise because of sea trade." Five hills are Rajgir, not Pataliputra. "Founded Pataliputra" and "made it capital" are different stems.

5.7 Haryanka Dynasty

First historical Magadha house | ~544–413 BCE | Buddhist and Jain, not the epic Brihadratha line

- **Bimbisara** (Shrenika / **Seniya** — titled *Seniya* because he was the first Indian king to maintain a regular and standing army) rules about **544–492 BCE** from **Girivraja**. He annexes **Anga**, reigns about 52 years, and makes three marriages. He is the real founder of the historical Magadha empire in Buddhist memory.
- **Jivaka**, his physician, also treats Pradyota of Avanti. He is a contemporary of the Buddha and of Mahavira.
- **Ajatashatru** (Kunika) rules about **492–460 BCE**. He is a parricide. He fights Kosala over Kashi, then marries Vajira.
- He fights a 16-year **Vajji** war with the **rathamusala** and the **mahashilakantaka**. Vassakara and Sunidha fortify Pataligrama — the seed later remembered as the foundation of Pataliputra.
- He is patron of the **First Buddhist Council** at Rajagriha. He claims a share of the Buddha's relics and raises a Rajagriha stupa.
- He is himself killed by his son **Udayin** for the throne — the same parricide pattern.
- **Udayin** (Udayibhadda) rules about **460–444 BCE**. He **shifts the capital from Rajagriha to Pataliputra**. Chandragupta Maurya did **not** found that city. Udayin of Magadha is **not** Udayana of Vatsa.
- Anuruddha, Munda, and Nagadasaka form a weak tail. Minister **Shishunaga** seizes the throne.
- Jetavana at Shravasti is the gift of **Anathapindika** in Kosala. It is not a Bimbisara building.

> **Logic:** Pataliputra is not a Mauryan foundation. **Ajatashatru** seeds / founds the town; **Udayin** first makes it the capital. Bimbisara is not a Nanda.

5.8 Shishunaga Dynasty

Minister's house | Avanti ends here | ~413–345 BCE

The Shishunagas take Magadha after the Haryanka weak tail. Their territorial prize is **Avanti**.

Rise and capitals

- **Shishunaga** is an ex-viceroy of Kashi.
- Some tellings call him a people's choice.
- He is often said to have sat first at **Vaishali**, then returned the court to **Pataliputra**.
- When he made Vaishali his capital, tradition remembers a son as deputy-king at **Varanasi**.
- That "second capital" reading is the stem some papers accept for Shishunaga.
- Rajgir stays a second city, not the capital of record.

Avanti and Kalashoka

- He crushes **Avanti** of the Pradyota line. Malwa enters Magadha.
- Ujjain enters Magadha. That is the dynasty's territorial fact.
- **Kalashoka / Kakavarna** holds the **Second Buddhist Council at Vaishali**, about **383 BCE**.
- The split at that council is **Sthavira / Mahasanghika**.
- The **king's name** on the paper is Kalashoka.

End of the house

- Puranic count gives ten Shishunagas.
- The last is often **Nandivardhana / Mahanandin**, overthrown by **Mahapadma Nanda**.

> **Logic:** Shishunaga did **not** found Pataliputra. He **did** take Avanti. Kalashoka is not the First Council.

5.9 Nanda Dynasty

First Gangetic "empire" | ~345–322 BCE | *Navananda*

- **Mahapadma Nanda** is also called **Ugrasena** (उग्रसेन). Puranic titles are **ekarat** (एकराट्), **sarvakshatrantaka** (सर्वक्षत्रान्तक - "destroyer of kshatriyas"), and **aparoparashurama** (अपरोपरशुराम). Hostile texts give a **shudra / barber** origin.
- He rolls up leftover Kuru, Panchala, Kosala, and Vatsa boards. The Hathigumpha later remembers a Nanda carrying off a Jina image from **Kalinga** (कलिंग) and digging a **canal** there. That inscription is **Kharavela's**, not a Nanda edict. It is also remembered as early canal-engraving evidence.
- Nine Nandas (*Navananda*) means Mahapadma plus eight sons. Coaching lists often name: Ugrasen / Mahapadma, Panduk, Pandugati, Bhootpal, Rastrapal, Govishanak, Dashasiddhak, Kaivart, and **Dhana Nanda**.
- The last is **Dhana Nanda**, the Greek **Agrammes / Xandrames**. His commander is remembered as **Bhaddasala**. Late Nanda rule is remembered for heavy taxes and unrest.
- Curtius gives an army of **2,00,000** infantry, **20,000** cavalry, **2,000** chariots, and **3,000** elephants. Treat it as order of size, not a muster roll. The numbers are enough that Alexander's army **stopped at the Beas**.
- **Dhana was not defeated by Alexander.** He is remembered as an unpopular tax-farmer. Chanakya's insult-story belongs here.
- **Chandragupta and Chanakya about 322 BCE** end the Nandas. That is the Mauryan start, not a Nanda reform.
- Centralised revenue and a standing four-fold army are the machine the Mauryas inherit. It is still **not** Ashokan dhamma, and not the *Arthashastra* as a finished book.
- At Pataliputra, Ashoka later holds the **Third Buddhist Council** under **Moggaliputta Tissa**. A first Jain convention tradition is also placed here. Those are Mauryan / Jain-council facts that use this capital, not Nanda reforms.

> **Logic:** Alexander never marched on Pataliputra. Mahapadma is not Chandragupta.

5.10 Northern Black Polished Ware (NBPW)

Archaeological marker of mahajanapada cities and second urbanisation | ~700–200 BCE | not PGW, not Harappan

- **Northern Black Polished Ware** (उत्तरी काली पॉलिश मृद्भांड / एनबीपीडब्ल्यू) is a fine, glossy, often metallic-looking black pottery. It marks elite table culture in early historic north India.
- The usual date-band is about **700–200 BCE**, from late mahajanapada growth through early Mauryan cities. It is **later** than PGW in stratigraphy.
- NBPW appears at urban and administrative sites: **Kaushambi**, **Rajghat** (Kashi), **Hastinapur**, **Shringaverapura**, **Taxila**, **Pataliputra**, and **Vaishali**.
- Wheeler and Krishna Deva named the ware at **Ahichchhatra**. Marshall had already noticed similar "fine black lustrous ware" at Sarnath and Bhita.
- NBPW is linked to **fortified towns**, punch-marked **silver** coins, writing, and specialised crafts. It is the pottery face of the **second urbanisation**.
- Early NBPW layers can sit with PGW, black-and-red ware, and plain grey ware. Later levels move toward coarse red and grey wares.
- NBPW is **not** limited to the Mauryan Empire alone. It begins in the **mahajanapada** age and continues into Mauryan strata.
- In the south, early historic sites may show NBPW imports, but the main production belt is the **Gangetic plain and the northwest**.

Ware	Date (approx.)	Key fact
OCP	Late 3rd–2nd millennium BCE	Doab rural, before PGW
PGW	~1100–600 BCE	Later Vedic doab
NBPW	~700–200 BCE	Mahajanapada + early historic cities

> **Logic:** NBPW ≠ PGW. NBPW ≠ "only Mauryan." Kaushambi and Ahichchhatra are classic NBPW mahajanapada facts.

UP Focus

Mahajanapada	Capital / district fact
Kashi	Varanasi
Kosala	Ayodhya + Shravasti (crescent plan)

Mahajanapada	Capital / district fact
Vatsa	Kaushambi (Prayagraj)
Kuru	Hastinapur (Meerut); Indraprastha = Delhi
Panchala	Ahichchhatra (Bareilly), Kampilya; Kanyakubja belt
Malla	Kushinagar
Surasena	Mathura
Chedi	Bundelkhand (Banda–Chitrakoot edge)
UP town (extra)	**Kalpi** — Yamuna, Jalaun; ancient Kalpriya